TSA Mock

Critical Thinking

The hardest past TSA Critical Thinking question of every type, from all 16 papers (2008–2023)

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Every question is a real past TSA question. The year and number in brackets show where it comes from, e.g. **7 (2019 Q32)**.

What is in this paper

At least one question of each of the 10 Critical Thinking question types that have come up in past papers, chosen as the hardest of its type: Applying a principle, Assumption, Draw a conclusion, Fill the gap, Flaw, Identifying a principle, Main conclusion, Parallel reasoning, Strengthen, Weaken.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to 25 questions: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes). These are hard questions, so expect to run short of time.

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (2014 Q47) Although boxing is unacceptable, other risky sports are not. When people get injured or killed in horse sports, motor sports or while climbing, yachting or skydiving it is because things have gone horribly wrong. When people get killed in boxing it is because things have gone horribly right. The aim of any boxing match is to cause more permanent brain damage to your opponent than you yourself sustain.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle underlying the argument?

A Laws are made to protect people from risks of which they are not fully aware.

B Medical treatment should be limited to those who do not pursue lifestyles which cause medical conditions.

C Spectator events where people take pleasure in others' misfortune should be banned.

D We should not make bonfire parties illegal in the way that arson is.

E Different attitudes to risk in life can be expressed in sport.

2 (2018 Q29) In a survey done by a school librarian during one year, borrowing of books in the library declined by 20%. Amongst books borrowed, rates of late return or loss of books also increased by 10%. On the other hand, student use of computers in the library increased by 25%. This finding was reinforced by frequent complaints from students that there were no computers available when they needed to use them. The librarian concluded that the best response to these findings was to cut the number of books and purchase more computers. 20% of books were sold off or given away, the space given over to additional computer tables, and the library's entire available budget given over to purchasing new computers.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the librarian's reasoning?

A The library should cater for the students' preferences rather than trying to change them.

B A decline in the borrowing of books indicates a decline in reading.

C Students were unjustified in complaining about the lack of computers.

D Students' educational achievement is improved by using computers.

E Library use will necessarily increase if more computers are provided.

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3 (2011 Q34)

The museum has decided to spend money in the hope of staying profitable and, therefore, remaining open. It has opened an expensive new front hall, which is very big and well planned, and will undoubtedly impress new visitors. For serious students, however, it has nothing to offer that was not there before. All the scholars who want to do so already use the museum, they will continue to come however artistic the displays may or may not be. So, it was a waste to spend so much money on appearances, the money should have been spent on improving conditions for those who come to study.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A The museum cannot be sure that new visitors will be attracted by its new front hall.

B There is no evidence that visitors to museums are interested in the conditions in which the contents are displayed.

C If scholars will continue to come anyway, the museum will not make more money by improving their conditions.

D There is no contact or sympathy between serious scholars and members of the general public in museums.

E It is regular users, and not potential new visitors, to the museum who deserve to be rewarded.

4 (2018 Q41)

The financial circumstances of many young people make it difficult for them to forego paid employment for an extended period in order to undertake unpaid internships or work experience placements. In many industries, it is unlikely that a young person will gain entry-level paid employment unless he or she has held one of these temporary unpaid positions. Therefore, the current system of unpaid internships creates an unfair advantage for individuals from more affluent backgrounds.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A Unpaid internships and work experience placements often provide young people with an important opportunity for gaining references.

B The highest proportion of unpaid internships and work experience placements are based in a few central locations, such as London.

C Unpaid internships and work experience placements come in various lengths of duration from one to two days up to a number of months.

D Some young people find themselves moving from one unpaid position to another without being able to land a paid job.

E Some schools and other organisations have programmes in place to help match young people with internships or work experience placements.

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5 (2021 Q23)

Conditions in some of the UK's prisons are scandalous. Inspectors found some prisons to be dirty, vermin-infested places, with frightening levels of violence and prisoners having easy access to illegal drugs. Some critics attribute the poor management of these prisons to the fact that the government has allowed private companies to run many prisons, although inspectors also criticised some state-run prisons. Others say the real problem is one of drastic funding cuts, affecting both state-run and privately-run prisons. Either way, we have allowed the situation to become very serious – and why? Because for the most part, we do not care. The truth is that, personally, we can much better imagine that at some point we'll need a clean, well-run hospital than a decent criminal justice system.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A People are more likely to support spending on hospitals than on prisons.

B The general public are not sufficiently aware of the scandalous prison conditions.

C The government should not allow private companies to run prisons.

D Funding cuts are the cause of the poor conditions in prisons, both state-run and private.

E Hospitals have been made a greater priority for spending than prisons.

6 (2022 Q45)

If he was telling the truth about the incident, then we would not expect him to look so nervous talking to the police. The fact that he looks so nervous suggests he is probably lying.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A If everyone who found themselves in the same position as Zach behaved the same way that he did, then we would be in an absolutely terrible situation. Fortunately for us, not everyone does behave in that way.

B The volume of waste they generate shows that most coffee companies do not care about the environmental impact of their businesses. If they did, they wouldn't serve coffee in disposable cups.

C If Bella really wanted to come to the party, then she would have told Anne. Unfortunately, since we are unable to contact Anne, we can't know if Bella really wanted to come.

D If Einstein's theory of relativity is correct, then we would expect light rays from distant stars to bend as they pass our own star. The fact that we are able to observe this suggests Einstein's theory is correct.

E No one who saw the game on Saturday would have thought it was between two sides at the very bottom of the league. If you'd seen the game, you would have agreed that the standard of football was impressively high.

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7 (2021 Q34)

The dark tendencies humans may have, such as psychopathy (lack of empathy), narcissism (excessive self-absorption), egoism and sadism are based on the same single underlying source: a drive to maximize one's individual interests, and to disregard or malevolently cause harm to others' interests. These tendencies often underlie the most serious violent crime in any society, usually dealt with by imprisonment. Psychiatrists say that people with these characteristics are notoriously difficult to change. This suggests that these personality traits are likely to be inherited genetic dispositions over which people have no control. It is wrong, therefore, to punish people for the actions that have resulted from such tendencies. The justice system should not imprison someone for actions over which they had no control.

Which one of the following best expresses the flaw in the above argument?

A It fails to show the research on which the psychiatrists' conclusions were based.

B It ignores differences in punishments between different countries.

C It implies that imprisonment is the only option for sentencing.

D It suggests that ways of altering serious antisocial behaviour can never be found.

E It assumes that the only objective of imprisonment is punishment.

8 (2022 Q15)

There is no denying the unwanted consequences of car emissions, burning of fossil fuels, chemical effluent, and other pollutants. Their negative effects include the increasing incidence of respiratory, skin, and heart conditions. But 'environments' consist of more than just the elements of air, earth, and water. Whilst it is quite right to headline the damage we are doing to our lungs and other bodily organs, it must not be thought that this is the only way in which we are polluting our world. The effects of artificial light and constant noise are also detrimental to mental and physical wellbeing. Many people, to their cost, rarely see the stars in the night sky, or experience the quiet of the natural environment in which our species evolved.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A The word 'environment' does not apply only to the elements of air, earth, and water.

B It is right to give prominent coverage to the damage human activity is doing to our bodies.

C It is wrong to think that pollution of the air, earth and water is the only form of environmental damage.

D The effects of artificial light and noise are physically and mentally harmful.

E Many people are deprived of the sight of the stars or the experience of natural silence.

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9 (2015 Q28) An intensely irritating fashion among politicians of all parties is to use the sound bite 'doing the right thing' to justify whatever action they have taken or propose to take. The phrase cleverly implies that if you do not agree with the action you are an immoral person – and no-one wants to be that. Taken to its logical conclusion, all we need are politicians who have some sixth sense that tells them what 'the right thing' is, and, hey presto, we can trust them to act on our behalf without any need for accountability. This is nothing short of dangerous brainwashing.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion of the passage above?

A Sound bites are used to avoid proper explanations for decisions.

B Politicians always think they know what is the right thing to do.

C Politicians should give proper rationales for their decisions, not glib sound bites.

D Irritating sound bites have the effect of alienating the general public.

E Politicians prefer to avoid giving a proper rationale for their decisions.

10 (2023 Q21) In recent years, the production and visibility of colourised and ‘restored’ historical photographs has grown exponentially, owing to both social media and the introduction of user-friendly colourisation software. But the expansion of the technical capacity and popular appetite to alter historical photography has not been matched by sufficient debate about the assumptions and consequences of this practice. Colourisers do not address photographs as physical artefacts with unique histories of creation and reception: they treat original photos as ‘windows’ onto the past that can be ‘improved’ for viewers. But a photograph is never just a neutral representation of the past. Every photograph carries with it a complicated history of who took it, who looked at it, how it was shaped by the technology behind it, and what all this means for questions of representation, experience, and history. Colourisation blocks out this rich repository of historical meaning, substituting a fleeting jolt of novelty for deeper understanding of the image.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A Artificial intelligence is now being used to colourise photographs automatically.

B Colourisation techniques are almost as old as photography itself.

C Some photographers of the past chose to use black and white film instead of colour.

D Some universities no longer teach courses on the history of photography.

E Colourisers rarely have academic experience of studying history.

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11 (2017 Q47) In a situation where every course of action is immoral, there still remains the ability to act for the greatest good for the greatest number. Therefore, the outsiders ought to be eliminated at the least possible cost and with the least possible delay. I am sorry to arrive at that conclusion, but it is the right step.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle contained in the above argument?

A The swiftest and cheapest option is often the least immoral action.

B The action that harms the least number of people is the best possible action.

C Where all options are immoral, it is necessary to consider cost and speed.

D An action cannot be considered totally immoral if it is the right action.

E An action cannot be considered totally immoral if it is done for the greater good.

12 (2023 Q47) In the USA, interest paid on a home loan is tax-deductible (meaning it can be deducted from your taxable income, reducing the tax you pay to the government). This tax break is known as mortgage interest deduction, and it should be abolished. After all, the poorest Americans generally rent their homes rather than owning them, and rent cannot be deducted from taxes. And certain technicalities related to how taxes are filed often prevent poorer homeowners from receiving the deduction. This means that the poorest Americans benefit the least from mortgage interest deduction. The people who benefit the most are the richest, since they own the most expensive houses and have the largest tax bills, and often employ accountants to file their taxes for maximum deductions. The American government could more than double rental assistance payments to poorer Americans with the money lost as a result of this tax break.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Government money should not be spent subsidising private household consumption choices.

B The financial benefits you receive from the government should not depend on whether you are rich or poor.

C Money raised by taxing the rich should be used to support the poor.

D There are no low-cost accounting services that poorer Americans can access.

E The government should not offer tax breaks that benefit the richest most and the poorest least.

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13 (2014 Q34) A recent peaceful demonstration against government cuts ended in violence caused by relatively small numbers of 'anarchists' attacking police and property. Anarchism is a political philosophy, and as a group, anarchists tend to be unable to agree among themselves on exactly what it means. But what does it tell us about these events or about those involved if we call everyone with a brick in their hand an anarchist? Given that the central idea all anarchists have in common is the abolition of the state (not necessarily by violence), 'anarchist' is a daft way to characterise the violent hangers-on of a demonstration protesting not for but against the shrinking of the state.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the argument above?

A The fact that some anarchists are peaceful does not mean that violent demonstrators cannot be anarchists.

B The protesters against government cuts are not protesting against a shrinking of the state.

C The presence of anarchists at a demonstration does not mean that they agree with its official aims.

D The diverse nature of anarchism makes it possible to call anyone an anarchist, as even they do not know exactly what the word means.

E The violent demonstrators want the Government to increase, not cut, spending.

14 (2021 Q40) In order for a gritted road surface to freeze over, temperatures must fall to −10 °C or below. Above this temperature, grit will continue to melt ice on the road. Since ice has formed even on treated surfaces in recent weeks, the temperature must have fallen below −10 °C at times.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A In order to make bread successfully it is essential that the oven reaches a temperature of 200 °C or above. If this is not reached or maintained, the bread will not rise properly. Since this bread has not risen, the oven must not yet be up to temperature.

B Temperatures of 37 °C and above cause chocolate to melt and release some of the oils it contains. When it cools again a whitish residue is left behind. Since this chocolate has a white residue, at some point it must have been kept at a temperature exceeding 37 °C.

C A fever is medically defined as an oral temperature exceeding 37.7 °C, but a diagnosis of fever may be given below this point. Since the patient's notes state that he had a fever on admission to hospital, we can be confident that his temperature was 37.7 °C or above at that time.

D Iron melts at temperatures in excess of 1538 °C. Without reaching this temperature it is impossible to cast iron. Although we do not know exactly how some of the earliest furnaces worked, since we have found evidence of cast iron in China from around 550 BCE, we can be sure that these ancient people found ways to reach temperatures exceeding 1538 °C.

E Ideally coffee should be stored below 5 °C once ground in order to help preserve its flavour. Stale coffee tastes bitter and can have a musty aroma. Since the coffee has been kept at room temperature, we should expect complaints about its flavour.

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15 (2017 Q35) We need to change science lessons so that they give children a correct view of modern science. Children are often taught in science lessons that matter can exist in three different states – solid, liquid and gas. However, developments in science suggest that this is far too simple a picture. Increased knowledge of the universe has shown that many other states of matter exist, for example, plasma and liquid crystal. Plasma is thought to be the state of 99% of matter in the universe, so the traditional states of matter are in a very small minority. So the traditional view is giving children a false, indeed unscientific, view of the universe.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A School science has failed to keep up with modern scientific developments.

B School science gives an over-simplistic view of the nature of matter.

C School science gives children an incorrect view of the universe.

D School science suggests matter is made up of three different states.

E School science should be updated so that it reflects modern science.

16 (2015 Q41) The main reason private schools thrive in Britain is that they are extremely good at getting their students into elite universities. In the UK only 7% of students attend private schools but they account for 40% of students at Oxford and Cambridge. As entry to the top universities is dependent on examination results (particularly A-level results), private school students must be achieving higher grades than those in the state sector. Higher grades are the result of good teaching, so the teaching in private schools must be better than the teaching in state schools.

Which one of the following, if true, would most weaken the above argument?

A A-levels are not the only exams that can be used for admission to Oxford or Cambridge.

B Only people from wealthy families can go to private schools.

C More than 40% of students at Oxford and Cambridge attended state schools.

D A higher proportion of private school candidates take A-levels than those from the state sector.

E Many private schools now accept scholarship students from poorer backgrounds.

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17 (2020 Q39) If the captain of a national team commits any kind of crime, he or she is likely to be dropped, heavily fined by the sport's governing body, or barred from future competition. This is on top of any punishment handed down by the courts. Senior politicians, doctors, judges or head teachers who offend also find themselves barred from their professions, with little or no chance of regaining their hard-earned status after serving their sentence. There is nothing unjust in this, although it is effectively a double punishment for a single offence. Privileged people must understand that with rewards come responsibilities, including the responsibility to behave in a more exemplary way than those in ordinary walks of life.

Which one of the following illustrates the principle underlying the above argument?

A A crime is a crime whoever commits it, and no exceptions should be made for highly placed people.

B A police chief who accepts a bribe deserves more blame than the criminal who offers the bribe.

C Leading sports personalities should understand that they are role models for young people.

D It is wrong to use the law to make an example of some people but not others.

E People on low incomes who commit offences should have reduced sentences.

18 (2019 Q29) Drivers found to be committing offences such as speeding are now offered the choice between paying the police for a re-education course or taking the traditional penalty of paying a fine and receiving penalty points on their licence. It is no surprise that the number of motorists opting for re-education courses has tripled in five years, but the high cost of such courses has led to accusations that police forces might use the new system for their own benefit. They could easily set up speed traps, catch a number of motorists slightly over the limit, and generate easy income for themselves. Re-education courses are a good idea in theory, but open to abuse by cash-starved police forces.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A The cost of running re-education courses is less than the combined contributions of participants.

B Re-education is more effective than punishment in preventing further motoring offences.

C Police forces are more interested in generating income than in preventing motoring offences.

D The number of driving offences committed in the last five years has tripled.

E Fear of losing a driving licence is greater than fear of financial hardship.

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19 (2022 Q49)

The government has recently announced that the method by which the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) is funded will be changed, leading to speculation that public funding for the organisation could soon be withdrawn. One of the complaints is that BBC TV and radio presenters “make their profile at public expense”, but then earn income on top of their salaries by charging to speak at events to which they are invited purely due to their association with the BBC. However, figures show that, over the last five years, Members of Parliament (MPs) received £8.4m on top of their salaries through similar activities. Until MPs can behave in a way that is consistent with their criticisms of others, this policy to change the funding of the BBC should be scrapped.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A BBC presenters make up a small proportion of all people invited to speak at events.

B Many MPs were established public figures before they entered Parliament.

C Many MPs have second or third jobs outside Parliament.

D Invitations to BBC presenters to speak at public events do not continue once the presenter has left the BBC.

E The BBC issues clear guidelines to its employees about the types of events that they are allowed to speak at.

20 (2012 Q40)

We should restore capital punishment for the offence of pre-meditated murder. It is true that, in the past, occasional mistakes have been made and innocent men have been hanged. However, with the improvements in forensic science and DNA testing, the chances of a mistake have receded. Restoring capital punishment would ensure real justice is done and, incidentally, it would also save the country a considerable amount of money in housing prisoners on long life sentences.

Which one of the following is an assumption of the above argument?

A Forensic science is a foolproof way of determining guilt.

B Real justice can still be achieved even if there are occasional miscarriages.

C Financial considerations are the most important factors when considering criminal justice legislation.

D Long life sentences will not deter people from committing murder.

E The public would not be against the restoration of capital punishment.

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21 (2018 Q21) When mobile phones first became relatively inexpensive many parents bought them for their teenage children on the grounds that having access to a phone would keep them safe. High profile cases of abduction at the time underscored the need to improve safety for young people. But today mobile phones invariably have access to the internet, which has made young people vulnerable to stalking and cyberbullying. Since the stated case for buying teenagers mobile phones was to keep them safe, we should now restrict their access to them.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A The incidence of cyberbullying and stalking does not undermine the respects in which mobile phones keep teenagers safe.

B If you restrict young people's access to mobile phones they will continue to bully one another on other devices.

C Access to mobile phones has not stopped teenagers from being attacked while out alone at night.

D The majority of teenagers are not affected by the problems of stalking and cyberbullying.

E It ignores the fact that there are other ways of keeping children safe.

22 (2023 Q49) To win business investment, you need a good product and a well-developed business plan. Your product is brilliant, but you haven't spent enough time on the plan. So it's unlikely you'll get funding.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A For the school to approve their proposal for meat-free lunches, the students must develop a menu and win support from their peers. The student body has approved their new menu in a poll, so it's unlikely the school will continue to serve meat.

B The only way their team will be disqualified is if they miss a match and fail to notify the tournament director at least three hours before the start of play. They couldn't attend the first match but told the director in plenty of time, meaning they won't be disqualified.

C The new hotel manager must be fluent in Mandarin and Korean. This candidate speaks both, meaning the hotel won't need to interview anyone else.

D To earn a distinction in music, you must perform in public concerts or write your own music composition. You don't have time for the concerts or the composition, so it's unlikely you'll earn a distinction.

E If they want to take a holiday that is affordable and unique, the friends can volunteer on a farm or at a nature reserve. The farm only hosts volunteers for the weekend, so they probably won't go there.

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23 (2022 Q47) One vision dominating much of urban planning worldwide is that of the 'smart city', whereby urban areas are pre-planned and designed to be managed via digital technology with efficiency prioritised as the top objective. But planners cannot foresee how cities will need to develop depending on cultural trends, changes in economic sectors, and other factors. We lose something important if we over-plan and over-manage our cities. The concept of the city as a pre-engineered machine works against critically important quality-of-life considerations. Once basic services, like transport, are in place, urban dwellers value community cohesion, opportunities for self-expression, and other quality-of-life features as much as or even more than efficiency. Such elements require openness, freedom of choice, and the opposite of central control in order to blossom.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Planners cannot foresee how cities will need to develop in response to various factors.

B We lose something important if we over-plan and over-manage our cities.

C The concept of the city as a pre-engineered machine works against important quality-of-life considerations.

D Urban dwellers value community cohesion and other quality-of-life features as much as or even more than efficiency.

E Community cohesion and other quality-of-life features require openness, freedom of choice, and the opposite of central control in order to blossom.

24 (2013 Q4) The International Code of Zoological Nomenclature states that the earliest recorded scientific name for an organism becomes the official name. This seems fair, but the system is flawed. Textbooks show the sequence of fossil ancestors of the modern horse as: *Pliohippus, Merychippus, Mesohippus* and the first horse ancestor *Hyracotherium.* The last of these looks out of place. *Hyracotherium* was once, more sensibly, called *Eohippus*; this descriptive name means "dawn horse". The suffix *-hippus* (horse) is consistent with others in the list. *Eohippus* also sounds pleasant. The name was changed when it was discovered that a fossil fragment that had been named *Hyracotherium* was really from the same animal that had, until then, been called *Eohippus*.

Which one of the following conclusions is best supported by the passage above?

A Common sense is not a major factor in scientific naming decisions.

B A system of naming organisms based on the date the name was first registered is not the most appropriate.

C The rules of the International Code of Zoological Nomenclature do not always produce the most sensible name for animals.

D The name of *Hyracotherium* should be changed back to *Eohippus*.

E The rules of the International Code of Zoological Nomenclature need to be changed to allow for common sense.

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25 (2011 Q46)

Land reform is urgently needed in the UK. It is well documented that around two-thirds of Britain is owned by just 0.3% of the population. Many of the largest estates have been in the hands of the same families for centuries, and were acquired under outdated feudal laws, often by means of aggression. If these families had any sense of social justice in the 21st century they would by now have voluntarily surrendered all but the acreage they needed for personal privacy. _____ the state should confiscate all excessive land holdings without compensation and redistribute them into the families of workers and taxpayers at affordable prices.

Which of the following phrases, inserted in the blank space, most logically completes the above argument?

A In the current economic climate, ...

B On the other hand, ...

C This being the case, ...

D Therefore, on legal grounds, ...

E Since they have not, ...

END OF TEST

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